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1. Introduction: The Indus as a Vein of Sound

Music is not only a set of tones but rather a conversation across time between the soul of humankind and the unseen. Rather than calling music as a strict formula of tunes, we must consider it from the "Sound as Spirit" perspective, which shows music as a heart organ used mainly to talk to the unseen without considering any physical and political boundaries. It emphasizes feeling more than technical aspects, becoming a universal language that unites various cultures and enables them to experience similar spiritual sensations despite their distinct styles.

In the case of South Asia, the Indus River is what can be called "Vein of Sound", which is a connection between spirituality. In terms of **samā** practiced by Sufi, the aim of spiritual listening is *hāl*, which is the state of mystical union where one's ego disappears. It is perfectly depicted in Jhulelal by linking the Hindu songs, for instance bhajans with those Muslim, such as qawwalis; see "Damā Dam Mast Qalandar". This tradition has several parallels on both sides of the river. For example, in Gilgit-Baltistan, bitan, the shamans utilize rhythmic Hareep for connecting with spirits. Similarly, in the Punjab region, Sikh Kirtan, the hymns are chanted to soothe the ego away. In case of Kalash too, it can be seen that rhythm is the language used to call the Supreme God, Deza. Overall, no matter if the rhythms are from north or dhikr from south, music is what ties our souls, transforming our innermost emotions into sounds.

2. Contemporary Pakistani Music: Media, Fusion, and the Persistence of the Sacred

The music from the Indus can never be forgotten easily. It carries on, it transforms & modifies due to the ever-changing technology and politics of everyday life. In this life cycle, when we evolved from the pre-digital era to the era of smart devices and associated technologies, our idea of private ownership and sacred traditions changed as well. In the past, traditional music was something that the people who related to it would cherish, but now the whole world can entertain from it together. This shows that music can evolve, fit new generations, but still carry the same meaning and importance as it did in the past.

After the formation of Pakistan, the government needed to work for the unity of the people, as Pakistan hosts people from a variety of cultures and traditions. For this purpose, Radio Pakistan and, later, PTV was created to bring people together and to let them experience each other's cultures. The local music, Qawwali, and milli nagmay were played on the radio to bring exposure to the population. This is considered a symbol of heritage. Playing the music on the radio or TV and making it accessible for everyone was of prime importance considering the amount of appreciation it got, and the positive results are brought.

In this process, the personal joy of a person who worshipped turned into something that the whole country could be proud of. People were reminded of their creator; it increased the love in the hearts of the local masses for the Almighty. Along with that, the people of the city got

reminded of their roots. This was also the era of Aziz Mian Qawwal; he was a one-of-a-kind personality. From his unique style of poetry, questioning the creator about the injustices in this world, to his “bayan” style performances, which made the people think outside the box. He wanted to find the truth, but in his own way, in a way that was not conventional or preferred. Sure, he was criticized but he brought the raw nature to the streets, and people will forever remember him as a great historical figure. He wanted to find the truth, but in his own way, in a way that was not conventional or preferred. Aziz Mian showed us that the Indus could survive in this world by mixing old and new styles.

Nowadays, shows like Coke Studio bridge the gap between the youngsters and their roots through spiritual music presented in a way that just feels right in the heart of the listeners. The spiritual music is combined with new technology; songs are carefully articulated by combining traditional verses with modern instruments such as electric guitars and drums. This mix brings down the generational gap created and is seen and heard by people around the world; it does not damage the divinity and the religious sacredness of the verses, but it is modified and presented in a new style. At the end of the day, this new success only works because it is still tied to the talent of folk musicians and the beat of their traditional instruments, the music of the Indus.

3. The Folk Music as Cultural Memory: Regional Traditions and Indigenous Instruments

While on the one side, digital airwaves of Coke Studio are pretty much a conception of the heritage, on the other side one can taste Pakistani music only on unmediated gatherings of people and their spiritual realism. Here music not only is heard but it is a part of a community, and it brings people together. The folk meetings of the folk, the people continue the spirit of the “national sound”, as the studio today strives to preserve the ‘national sound’. Music is the experience of listening; not alone using rhythm, movement and participation.

The commonest one is the folk dances of the North and the marriage ceremonies of Punjab. These values are then very evident in the community's music and dance, with unity being very strong in these areas. An effective dancer is not only in tune with the music, but people also communicate with the musicians through dance movements and gestures, eye movement and movement of the shoulders to indicate changes in tempo and melody. This inner voice of dancer and musician brings spiritual celebration with no physical movement, it is dance and play together in harmony with the group. These are the times when the music is present, one has to be present to the music.

Likewise, in the folk songs of Punjab a similar effort has been made and the folk singers like ‘Sain Zahoor’ exude the ecstatic spirit of the shrine in the gatherings of the local community. Traditional songs have now been composed with contemporary rock and pop songs and are being performed in modern day Punjabi and Hunza marriage ceremonies. Not necessarily a loss of

tradition, though, it would seem, rather a means of attempting to maintain the tradition in the face of changing times. Older folk songs and newer sounds are used to connect to the older culture and at the same time be a part of the culture around them that they live in.

Furthermore, folk music can be used to convey a social feeling and social grievance. The Bitan (shaman) is a part of Gilgit-Baltistan culture, who enters in trance and communicates with spirit through music. However these performances are not solely of a religious character. Within these rituals a shaman can talk about injustice of taxes, expose injustice or condemn the unfair deeds of the upper class through spiritual communications. Perhaps the 'music' aspect is the most important thing about the ritualized space because there is a place where feelings of dissatisfaction can be expressed, and the ordinary will face punishment if they complain of such feelings.

These practices highlight the profound nature of Pakistani folklore and its ability to unite people through shared experiences, emotions, and beliefs. Whether the Punjabi folk ballad or the Northern Hareep song or the trance like mountain rituals, Music is a means of uniting the society together, surpassing the individual. The listener doesn't simply hear music, but expression and a way of communicating that is centuries old and integral to the emotional and spiritual life of the people. Through rhythm, repetition and community involvement, music helps to keep the social and spiritual identity of the nation alive and holds the invisible thread together that ties the various communities of the nation together.

4. Sacred Landscapes and Devotional Unity: Music, Place, and Coexistence

In Pakistan, spirituality can be described in terms of "sacred topographies," which means that geographical areas are transformed into sacred spaces through processes of moving and sounding. Sacred topographies are not fixed; rather, they become imagined spaces when the physical landscape and mythic landscape converge.

Tirtha as Sound: Chandrakup In this regard, the mud volcano of Chandrakup in Balochistan is one of the important stops in a journey to Hinglaj Devi. Here too, topography becomes a process of bodily movement in order for the spiritual experience to take place. The pilgrim has to climb the volcano and confess his/her sins in front of the mouth of the volcano (tapasyā). In the Chandrakup mud volcano, the process of becoming real (xālis) takes place in terms of the combination of movement and sound. This is because pilgrims interpret the bubbles of the mud as a response from God. Pilgrims recite the mantras "Jai Mata Di" and certain bhajans, requesting strength for the caravans.

Gurbani Sangeet of Sikhs In Punjab, the practice of Kirtan (or Gurbani Sangeet) in Sikhism is a community activity created by Guru Nanak as a means of overcoming barriers between social classes and reducing egotistical tendencies. Unlike older practices that only permitted certain castes from joining in, Guru Nanak removed restrictions and promoted the practice of Kirtan, recognizing community singing as the highest form of spirituality to unify the mind and the divine. One such icon representing the inter-religious history of this tradition is the Rabab, an instrument which Guru Nanak used to sing along with his constant companion, who was a Muslim named Bhai Mardana.

The Plurality of Sindhi Culture: The Worship of “Lal” Sindh is one of the provinces that illustrate a phenomenon of “syncretic nationalism,” where music plays an important role as a bridge among different communities based on worship. The Jhulelal, also referred to by Muslims as Khwaja Khizr or Zinda Pir, is a common figure worshipped by Hindus and looked upto by the Muslim communities. Both the music of Jhulelal Bhajans and the well-known Sufi song “Dama Dam Mast Qalandar” are considered instruments of unity. The song “Dama Dam Mast Qalandar” calls upon “Lal,” which also refers to the Sufi saint Lal Shahbaz Qalandar and Hindu god Jhulelal. Thus, it represents a notable being that is remembered by both religions. The music of “Lal” helps create a link between Hindus and Muslims; the popular singer Reshma, who sang the song, was born in a rural folk background.

5. Trance, Ritual, and the Sound of Silence: Indigenous Spiritual Practices

Sound represents something more for numerous individuals residing in Pakistan than just audible noise. It also has emotional and spiritual components to it. Sound is utilized as a method of connecting with a divine being by individuals living in places like Gilgit-Baltistan or the coastal plains of Sindh, through music or dance and even silence.

In Kalash thought, the universe is a large wheel (or cycle) that is always turning. The sun rises, the rivers flow and the seasons change, and all of this occurs without interruption. Because humans are made from the same earth and water as what is seen in nature, it is believed that humans will have a relationship with the cycle of the universe.

As a result of this belief, music and continual dancing plays an important role in Kalash ceremonies. Dance does more than convey celebration; dance also keeps a person spiritually aware and connected to the universe. For the Kalash community, rhythm serves as a means of connecting the physical and spiritual realms. It can be achieved through the playing of instruments, clapping, or dancing.

Kalash also believe that sound can connect to the energy of one's body. Because the body is composed primarily of water, the vibration of rhythm may begin to make internal changes and open up a person's life-force.

Shamans who practice in Gilgit-Baltistan use music and smoke to enter trance states. Hareep is said to attract spirits or *pari*, and they are not considered typical songs, but rather as a channel to the spirit world.

The first step in the ritual is to burn juniper smoke called *gal thomal* (the "food" of spirits), and once lit, the shaman will shake violently; this is an indication that the spirits are coming.

As the drums start beating harder and the smoke is becoming more disperse, the shaman will jump off as hard as they can during the drumbeats; this moment is interpreted as that they have given their physical body up to be guided by spirit energy.

The shrine of Lal Shahbaz Qalandar contains a comparable form of spirituality with the addition of *dhamal*. Participants move in circles, jerk their heads backward, and elevate their arms while drums keep playing behind them. As the beat increases, participants enter a state of *hāl* (spiritual ecstasy). Ultimately, participants will stop identifying themselves as individuals. When the drumming is incessant, they can let go of their thoughts and transcend the boundaries of mental activity.

Many sufis believe that *dhamal* eliminates the ego, or the identification with "I" and "me" that prevents a person from feeling their connection to the Divine.

While some spiritual paths search for truth through loud music, others believe that true understanding will only be experienced in silence. Many temples and places of meditation regard silence as a sacred state, as it offers people the opportunity to experience their "inner sound" and connect with the existence surrounding them.

Mystics liken the mind to a lake; when the surface of the lake is disturbed by the emotional and mental activity of a person's thoughts, truth cannot be properly reflected within the depths of the lake. Once the surface of the lake is smooth, like a still body of water, the deeper levels of truth are revealed.

6. Classical Roots and Mystical Longing

Though the pulse of Pakistani music is its beautiful and diverse instruments, its soul, however, lies in the sophisticated and classical traditions that function as the metaphysical foundation of its musical identity. One example of such traditions is *Shah jo Raag*, which is associated with the shrine of the 18th-century Sufi poet Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai. It is not merely a musical genre, but a living connection to the land and the language of Sindh. In this tradition, music serves as a dialogue between the mortal and the Divine. The poetry is carefully plucked from *Shah Jo Risalo* (the anthology of poetry by Bhittai), which focuses on divine love through allegories and describes the state of *be-ikhtiyari* (severe helplessness).

Losing oneself in the Beloved is one of the core themes of Sufistic music, and oftentimes, as mentioned before, it is written in the form of allegories. Descriptions of intense romantic love in our folk tales are used as metaphors for the love of the Divine. This can be derived from the fact

that most of our folk stories, like Heer and Ranjha or Sassui and Punnun, were written by some of the greatest Sufi poets to have lived in their eras. The almost maddening pursuit of the beloved by the lover is, in fact, used to showcase the spiritual journey of an individual toward God. One such example of this is the verse by Hashim Shah regarding Sassui as she treads the desert of Thal to look for her lover:

*“Naazuk pair malook Sassi de,
Jehri thal vich haaye maare
O tapdi rait, tatti thalaan di,
Jehri wal di wang angare”*

From a philosophical perspective, Sassui’s journey through the burning sand represents the annihilation of the ego. The physical torture is the “self” enduring the pain of letting go of its ego to become one with the Divine. When these verses are sung, the repetition and melody intensify these emotions and transform the song into a spiritual experience of its own. The same theme appears in this verse by Fariduddin Ganjshakar, who writes:

*“Kaga sab tan khaiyo, chun chun khaiyo maas
Do naina mat khaiyo, mohe piya milan ki aas”*

Even physical agony is considered trivial in front of the longing for the One.

All in all, these traditions reveal that the music of Pakistan is not merely for entertainment, but a mass journey toward the Greater Truth. The listener is not merely hearing a performance, but is actively participating in century-old dialogues between the lover and the Beloved, carried through rhythm, poetry and devotion. Every repetition of a verse, every intricate raag, and every cry of the lover turns music into an act of remembrance for the soul, trying to get to its forgotten home. It is a recollection of the memories of the soul, sung to remember the very origins of this world. Whether through qawwali, Shah jo Raag, or other folk ballads, music becomes the bridge between the unseen realms and physical matter, reinstating the soul to its divine status.

7. Conclusion: The Shared Human Condition

When we look at the various types of music that exist throughout the Indus, we can be quite sure that although there may be a difference in the style, the spirit within remains the same. Starting from the trance-like songs of a bitan in the north all the way to the repetitive songs of dhikr in the south, there exists in these pieces an underlying essence of the human condition which is very fundamental and one that is shared by everyone. This search for transcendence beyond the material realm is a never-ending pursuit. This journey through the **"Vein of Sound"** shows us that the spiritual state and the everyday rhythms of a society and region are really just two sides of the same coin. Whether it’s the specialized **Hareep** music used in Gilgit-Baltistan to help a

shaman reaches a stage of joy. **Chowmus** dancing among the Kalash people, which is done to gain energy from the cosmos, sound becomes the best connection between the visible and invisible worlds. Sound is the means by which the imaginary becomes real, enabling individuals to discover truth in the midst of the “Sound of Silence”. In the final analysis, the music in the Indus Valley area cannot be explained by culture alone; rather, it is vibrant and dynamic. It serves as a repository of memory for the soul. This is evident in the old songs performed during contemporary weddings and the hunt for the sacred through traditional poetry. These sounds contain identity that remains unchanged regardless of the passage of time.